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Design Thinking

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Thinking about Design in a Different Way

This class has been a meaningful part of my spring term for various reasons. Firstly, it was a different approach to learning with lots of hand work and constant conversations with users. In high school in Uzbekistan, most of my learning was based on pure memorization (Post Soviet integration) and homework rarely involved group work. I found it fascinating that we could be a ‘thinking body’ and a ‘training mind’. I mean, we can think with our hands literally by just trying different techniques until foamcore can come into an expected shape. We can train our mind to find prejudices and assumptions we have about our environment and what people really need. Awkwardness I found in user interviews now brings me a laugh that they say hi to me whenever they see me—a new way to make friends!

Secondly, it introduced a lot of concepts that can be applied to almost any field, and we call them in class ‘tools.’ Since I’m interested in cognition of mind and politics, I can think about various interventions that help improve SDG goals, for example, similar to what we did in project 6. Concepts include like lateral thinking, which is considering all alternatives; user journeys, which is mapping where the user starts and ends to have one particular experience; user persona, which is all about their background and what assumptions they have. I believe all of these will be helpful, as I’ll be taking classes in Human-Centered Design. Really, in an era with

the fear of takeover of AI and technology, we can embrace it and be an artsy girl who's into technology.

Thirdly, I made a lot of friends in general. I think this is the most authentic part of the class. I like quiet deep working and I like working alone usually. This class pushed me to get along with new people quickly (which is team work, a required skill for the 21st century). In the second project, I was a little bird trying to soar but had a bumpy start at first. However, as I went into other team projects, I found myself better adjusting to team collaboration and actually had good time with people. I learned about them and they learned about me. I asked tons of questions about South Korea and shared my admiration about the country with Grace; Paola likes learning Spanish; Oscar is always ready to help; Dorotea says 'don't worry' and is the calmer; I can reach out to Jack about video editing; Amanda is good at speech and imitating French accent; Sienna has always some funny things to joke about; and Caleb is a thoughtful listener. I think it's fun that a class group work isn't merely about completing homework.

In the future, I see myself taking a bunch of anthropology, design, and psychology classes. As I mentioned, the frameworks and concepts learned in this class can be applied to any class, I believe. Anthropology is all about ground work of interviewing people and trying to understand their situation in their honest context possible. Additionally, I'm doing a research project and documentary about rural women's relationship with water and water journeys in Karakalpakstan this summer with the funding from Dartmouth. This is a very exciting independent study for me that I'm going to 'examine and study' my own land and how women collect water in rural areas. Having taken this class, I feel like I've collected a lot of skills and tools to enhance this summer study. Furthermore, I'm going to take Design & Education class because I realized I would fail to bring any meaningful work if I would've settled into only the

first idea. Working with whiteboards and having clear communication with teammates will help me so much in the long run.

Lastly, design and reading logs in general made me a better person to reflect and take notes of what I read and see in a meaningful way. In a fast-paced environment like Dartmouth, it's hard to stop and pause to question what we're trying to get out of all of this. And this might lead us to question why it matters in the first place. Therefore, it's important to step back and work with hands a lot. I personally don't like working with a laptop too long, and I liked how we've kept lists of bugs and delights each week. This exercise helped me see that I actually have something to be grateful for and something that bothers me that I can work on. Some skills like working with Photoshop, iMovie, Adobe tools, and video making are going to be resourceful in general. I think each project was well thought out and well-explained in descriptions.

It's been an amazing experience – made me minor in Human-Centered Design and changed the way I looked at problems in society completely. It makes one an entrepreneur! And as a very final note, TA sessions were helpful and were always available for help. I think the Designing Your Life series was a complementary part of the class and made me rethink majors!